

RETAILSPHERE (PTY) LTD

BPA-001 — Stakeholder Interview Reference

Interview 5 — Johan van der Merwe

Full Name	Johan van der Merwe
Title	Group Financial Controller
Domain	Finance
Interview Date	17 April 2026
Interview Status	Complete
Experience	22 years as Financial Controller. 4 data platform projects. 2 abandoned. 1 decommissioned. 1 still running after 3 years.
Critical Condition	Platform and Excel run simultaneously for minimum 3 consecutive months before Excel decommission. Johan's sign-off required.
Key Requirement	Reconciliation framework enforcing data lineage. Every Gold layer number traceable to SAP to the cent.

1. Process Owner Profile

Johan van der Merwe is the Group Financial Controller with 22 years of experience. He owns the Finance domain at RetailSphere and is personally liable for the accuracy of financial statements — incorrect reports could cost him his professional registration, reputation, and potentially carry legal consequences. He has outlasted four data platform projects at four different companies and walked into the interview with zero expectations. He left with cautious trust — earned by one specific answer: the platform stops before it shows a number it cannot defend.

Johan's condition for cooperation: The platform and Excel workbooks must run simultaneously for a minimum of three consecutive months before Excel is decommissioned. All three months must reconcile to the cent. Johan's sign-off is required. This is non-negotiable.

2. Key Business Processes

Month-end Close

- Johan's team closes the books every month using 140 Excel workbooks built over 11 years.
- Every formula has been audited. Every number has been checked. Never had a qualified audit opinion.
- Month-end close currently takes 3 days — the platform must deliver the same output by 7am on day 2.

Three-way Invoice Matching

- SAP matches Purchase Order + Goods Receipt Note + Invoice.
- When match fails — invoice goes to exceptions queue.

- Current exceptions queue: 847 invoices. Some six months old. Managed in Excel by Finance creditors team.
- Unreconciled creditors at year-end = audit finding = material weakness.

Late Arriving Invoices — Restatement Process

- SAP closes at midnight on last day of month.
- Supplier invoices continue arriving for up to 5 days after month-end — backdated to previous month.
- March creditors balance on day 1 of April differs from balance on day 6.
- Both numbers are correct at the time produced. But they look like a discrepancy.
- Currently: Johan's team spends 2 days hunting through SAP to explain the difference.
- Platform solution: Capture both transaction date and posting date. Keep both versions of the period. Store the reason. Restatement approval workflow built in.

SAP Backdated Postings

- SAP allows backdated postings — a transaction posted today can carry a date 3 months ago.
- Platform extracts SAP data last night. Backdated posting made this morning. Gold layer missed it.
- Platform solution: Detect backdated postings within 1 hour. Send alert to Johan with full details. Restatement approval workflow. Never silently update Gold layer.

3. Decisions Made — Daily, Weekly, Monthly

Daily

- Monitor SAP for posting errors and system issues.
- Review exceptions queue — any new invoices that failed three-way match.
- Check for backdated postings that may affect prior period balances.

Weekly

- Review creditors aging — how long invoices have been in exceptions queue.
- Monitor cash flow position — payments due vs available funds.

Monthly

- Month-end close — 3 days. 140 Excel workbooks. Board presentation.
- Produce procurement savings number for Siphos board report.
- Produce creditors aging analysis for audit trail purposes.
- Sign off on financial statements — personal legal liability.

4. Questions Johan Cannot Currently Answer

- Why does my March creditors balance on day 1 differ from day 6 — and can I explain every rand of the difference in seconds rather than 2 days?
- Which of the 847 exceptions queue invoices will never match and need to be written off — and how old are they?
- When SAP is queried tonight — what backdated postings were made today that my Gold layer will miss?
- Can I show an auditor exactly where every number in the board report came from — column by column, transformation by transformation — without spending a week in spreadsheets?

5. What Good Looks Like in 12 Months

Johan's five Gold layer requirements — in priority order:

Requirement 1 — General Ledger Reconciliation Report (PRIORITY 1)

Platform number = SAP number. Always. Variance report showing any difference with drill-down to transaction level. Audit trail available within 24 hours of any auditor request.

Requirement 2 — Month-end Close Pack

Automated. Same format as current Excel. Delivered by 7am on day 2 of new month. Johan's team gets 3 days back every month.

Requirement 3 — Creditors Aging Analysis

All 847 exceptions resolved and tracked. Automated three-way matching logic. Exception queue visible and managed in platform — not Excel.

Requirement 4 — Backdated Posting Alert

Every backdated SAP posting flagged within 1 hour of detection. Alert contains: what changed, by how much, why, what period affected, approve or reject restatement. Restatement approval workflow built in.

Requirement 5 — Audit Trail Report

Every number. Every transformation. Every business rule. Every change. Exportable to PDF for auditors. Available within 24 hours of request.

Johan's exact instruction: Make sure the audit trail is section one. Not section five. Section one.

6. Data Sources and Quality Issues

Source Systems

- Primary: SAP ECC 6.0 — General Ledger, accounts payable, accounts receivable, cost centres, payment runs.
- Excel workbooks — 140 workbooks. 11 years of accumulated business rules. Some rules verbal agreements with CFO. Exist nowhere else. Must be documented before decommission.
- SQL Server Legacy DW — two undocumented reports built 2019. Used monthly. Nobody else knows they exist. Must be discovered, replicated, and migrated before Q3 2026 decommission deadline.

Critical Data Quality Issues

Issue 1 — Business Rules Trapped in Excel

140 Excel workbooks contain business logic that exists nowhere else. Some rules were verbal agreements with the CFO. These rules must be extracted, documented, and converted to dbt transformation models before Excel can be decommissioned. This is a process problem not a structural one — it is solvable with the right plan.

Issue 2 — Legacy DW Undocumented Reports

Two mystery reports built in 2019. Used monthly by Finance. Undocumented. Nobody else knows they exist. Legacy DW must not be decommissioned before these reports are discovered, understood, replicated in the platform, tested by Johan for two consecutive months, and signed off. CDO decommission deadline: Q3 2026.

Issue 3 — SAP Backdated Postings

SAP allows transactions to be posted with past dates. Platform extraction runs nightly. A backdated posting made after extraction is missed. Gold layer becomes wrong without knowing it. Solution: Change Data Capture or daily re-extraction with backdated posting detection.

7. Architectural Implications

The most important functional requirement for Finance — stated directly by Johan:

Reconciliation Framework Enforcing Data Lineage

Every Gold layer number must trace back to SAP to the cent. At every layer boundary — Bronze to Silver, Silver to Gold — automated checks compare totals. If Bronze revenue $\neq$ SAP revenue the pipeline stops. Alert fires. No wrong number reaches Gold.

Without this: Johan will not trust the platform. Without trust: Johan returns to Excel. Without Johan: the board sees nothing from the platform.

- dbt transformation models replace Excel formulas — visible code, version controlled, auditable, changeable only through approved pull requests.
- Two timestamp columns on every invoice record: `transaction_date` (when the invoice period) and `posting_date` (when SAP recorded it).
- Two versions of every period: original close and restated close. Reason stored. Auditor can see both with full explanation.
- Backdated posting alert: detects posting within 1 hour, sends alert with full details, requires Johan approval before Gold layer restatement.
- Legacy DW migration plan — five steps: Discovery → Replication → Validation (2 months side by side) → Cutover → Decommission.
- Excel decommission plan — 3 months parallel running minimum. Johan signs off each month. Not IT's decision. Johan's decision.

8. The Three Problems That Have Killed Previous Platforms

Problem 1 — Business rules trapped in Excel

Solution: Extract all rules. Convert to dbt models. Version control. Audit trail. Every rule visible and approvable.

Problem 2 — Legacy DW reports nobody knows about

Solution: Discovery session with Johan's team. Replicate both reports in platform. Two months side-by-side validation. Johan signs off before decommission.

Problem 3 — SAP backdated postings

Solution: Capture `transaction_date` and `posting_date` separately. Detect backdated postings within 1 hour. Alert Johan. Restatement approval workflow. Never silently update Gold layer.

9. Key Quote

"The Finance domain will make or break this platform's credibility with the board. If my numbers are right — the board will trust every other number the platform produces. If my numbers are wrong once — even once — the board will question everything."

— Johan van der Merwe, Group Financial Controller

"You are the first person from IT who has ever led with the audit trail."

— Johan van der Merwe, on being asked what the platform can do that Excel cannot

— End of Interview Reference — Johan van der Merwe